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1985

Year Gambhira-Mujpur bridge was constructed in India's Gujarat state

141 people
were killed in 2022
after another bridge
collapsed in Gujarat

A BRIDGE TOO FAR

Rescuers and locals look for survivors after several vehicles fell into a river following the collapse of a portion of a bridge in Mujpur near Vadodara in India's Gujarat, yesterday. The bridge gave way during peak traffic hours around 7am, sending several vehicles plunging into the Mahisagar (Mahi) River. At least 11 people lost their lives in the incident, once again raising serious concerns about infrastructure safety in India.

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US push for Gaza truce likely to see results by this weekend

Witkoff says talks have resolved three of the four contentious issues

WASHINGTON

US President Donald Trump's Special Envoy to the Middle East Steve Witkoff said Tuesday that he is "hopeful" that a 60-day ceasefire in Gaza will be agreed to by the week's end following progress in proximity talks.

"We had four issues, and now we're down to one after two days of proximity talks," Witkoff said on Tuesday at a Cabinet meeting. "So, we are hopeful that by the end of this week, we will have an agreement that will bring us into a 60-day ceasefire," he added.

Witkoff said 10 living hos-

Israel's foreign minister Gideon Saar maintained that Israel was serious about wanting to reach a deal to end the 21 months of bitter fighting.

tages will be released under the proposed agreement, expressing hope that "this will lead to a lasting peace in Gaza."

Meanwhile, Israel's foreign minister yesterday voiced confidence about reaching a ceasefire and hostage-release deal in war-torn Gaza, despite no immediate signs of a breakthrough in ongoing talks with Palestinian militant group Hamas.

Gideon Saar maintained that Israel was serious about wanting to reach a deal to end the 21 months of bitter fighting in the

devastated territory, and believed it was "achievable". "If a temporary ceasefire is achieved, we will negotiate on a permanent ceasefire," he added in a speech in the Slovakian capital Bratislava, as the indirect talks between the two sides stretched into a fourth day in Doha.

Saar's comments — echoing optimism from Witkoff — came after Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu on Tuesday met US President Donald Trump for the second time this week in Washington.

Netanyahu promised no let-up in the military campaign and "the elimination of Hamas's military and governing capabilities". But Hamas said it would never give up. "Gaza will not surrender... and the resistance will impose the conditions, just as it imposed the equations," a statement read.

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Now you can chat using your phone's Bluetooth

Bitchat comes to town with digital twist

DUBAI

BY JAY HILOTIN

Senior Assistant Editor

Imagine a messaging app that refuses to play by the rules of the internet, phone numbers, or even centralised servers.

That's Bitchat — a peer-to-peer platform that lets you chat with anyone, anywhere, using nothing but your phone's Bluetooth Low Energy (BLE) and a dash of cryptographic flair.

Its founder Jack Dorsey — of Twitter (now X) and payments juggernaut Block fame — announced the app on X, describing it as a "personal experiment" in alternative connectivity — a way to keep people talking even when the internet is down, censored, or sim-

ply unavailable. Within hours, the beta version on Apple's TestFlight maxed out its 10,000 tester limit, with curious users eager to try a messaging app that doesn't ask for a phone number, registration, or even an email address.

Random peer IDs

Instead, Bitchat generates random peer IDs each time you use it, keeping your identity as ephemeral as your messages.

Devices within about 30 metres form clusters, relaying encrypted messages from one to another. As people move, their devices can bridge clusters, allowing messages to travel far beyond standard Bluetooth range — think digital walkie-talkies with superpowers.

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AI to help track government performance

NEW SYSTEM TO ENHANCE EFFICIENCY, SERVICES AND OPTIMISE RESOURCES

DUBAI

BY KHITAM AL AMIR

Chief News Editor

His Highness Shaikh Mohammad Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, has launched the Proactive Government Performance System, which aims to enhance government performance, improve service delivery, and achieve the strategic goals of the 'We the UAE 2031' vision.

By leveraging advanced AI-powered data analytics, predictive capabilities and in-depth analysis, the system will translate the vision's objectives into measurable and actionable results.

Shaikh Mohammad said: "The Federal Government has launched a new performance measurement system that leverages artificial intelligence to enhance decision-making, strengthen oversight of strategic planning, and improve the ability to anticipate future challenges and opportunities."

"Our commitment to continuous improvement is unwavering. We strive for excellence and aspire for perfection, fully aware that continuous development is essential to progress."

The system aims to enhance government efficiency and effectiveness through several key functions. It optimises resource

45 times
more results can be measured annually by the new system

use, improves service quality, and monitors the timely implementation of national strategies and plans. It also provides accurate data for decision-making, and promotes transparency through performance monitoring and review.

Impressive capabilities

The system demonstrates impressive capabilities, with an ability to process over 150 million data points monthly. It can measure 45 times more results annually, increasing entities' self-management capacity by 90 per cent, and providing leadership with over 50,000 proactive insights annually. By training 200 employees in performance management and data analysis, the system saves over 250,000 hours per year and is ultimately set to support over 250,000 users.

The system's interconnected design ensures data quality, integration, security, and transparency, supporting accurate and proactive decision-making for enhanced government efficiency.

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